



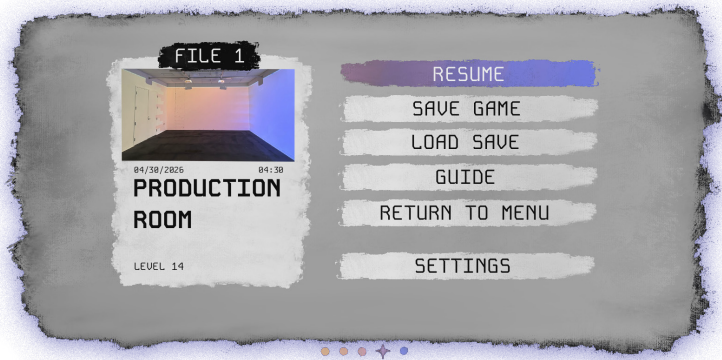
I PAUSED
MY GAME 2 B
w/
YOU....



AN ANTHOLOGY OF EXPERIMENTAL
WRITING AND REFLECTION ON
ART + GAMES + ANIME

DISPATCHES FROM THE GAMING CLOSET #2 : I PAUSED MY GAME 2 B w/ U ...





DISPATCHES FROM THE GAMING CLOSET #2 :

I PAUSED MY GAME 2 B W/ U ...



INTRODUCTION

SHAWNÉ MICHAELAIN HOLLOWAY

i paused my game 2 b w/ u is a publication built on the philosophy that assumes that our art practices are places we can bring in any and all of our interests. In our workshop time, we took four weeks to watch and read about anime and another four to do the same with video games. We each chose one title from each media to spend time with alone in our studios and chose one of those two to write about. We asked participants to approach writing about these titles in non-traditional ways. Participants could write poetry, write reviews, personal essays or otherwise (any other form of essay other than the traditional research paper); they were also asked to provide an annotated bibliography. These pages contain the results of 15 weeks together. We played collective games (Thanks Sanai!), watched vintage anime, had difficult conversations about social topics, and peer edited each other's work with generosity and curiosity. Thank you for reading! What follows are resources from past classes as well as from the writers in this publication. We hope these lists are useful for you. <3 Happy reading, watching, playing.





TABLE OF CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION	2
<i>SHAWNÉ MICHAELAIN HOLLOWAY</i>	
Diamandra's Mirror	12
<i>G.A.AA</i>	
The Lost Japanese Island	27
<i>Melissa Delaney + Jake Mullins</i>	
"Enter Lil' Slugger"	30
<i>Julia Velazquez</i>	
Cuphead: The Battle of Katnip Kollege	33
<i>Katy Kunberger</i>	
"So how does the story of the wolf brothers end?":	36
<i>Luka Tenney</i>	

Somewhere in Between	42
<i>Markus Chu</i>	
Persona: Master the Self	45
<i>Masa</i>	
Kitten's Perfect Studio	51
<i>Melissa Delaney</i>	
Night in the woods: Girl alone in a world	53
<i>Sara Simensky</i>	
A Super Galaxial Journey	57
<i>Senai</i>	
Milgram, I'm so confused but, I'm invested	61
<i>Frank Agama Perez</i>	
Contributors	67
Resource Archive	74

The FLCL Experience

Ana Pierowski



Think of warm summer nights sticky with humidity clinging like honey to your skin, sitting on sidewalk curbs overlooking a horizon crisscrossed with metal poles tied by wires like constellations and aircraft fluttering between the stars above. You are a kid again, trying to understand a big, complicated world in which the only thing you know for sure is that it doesn't think you are ready for it just yet. You are unbearably young, and

you just want to be treated like everyone else: your big brother, already off making something of his life, or the eccentric stranger who maybe loves you, or is maybe just using you but doesn't ever explain why. This is the essence of growing up that Fooly Cooly, abbreviated FLCL, attempts to capture. It is commentary about nostalgia, maturity, and the beautiful strangeness of small town life in a much greater world, explored through a character that is somehow simultaneously specific to this unusual science fiction setting yet relatable to anyone who's ever been a lonely 12 year old. I think that's precisely why I found myself so enamored with this series despite its short run.

Though, being a series whose sole purpose was to break the ordinary rules of anime¹, the element that caught my attention first was the visual experimentation throughout the series. Back to back scenes rapidly change style from "standard" anime to action-packed manga panels with full speech bubbles that drop you right in the middle of a rowdy dinner party between bickering

1 Carl Gustav Horn, "FLCL is the Formula," Pulp: The Manga Magazine, March 2002.

adults who are drunk beyond responsibility². Drawing techniques also shift, varying in line work and character proportions; an entire scene was even animated in 2D paper cutout mimicking the style of South Park for no rational reason, other than it was jarring and comedic³. Each creative decision has precise intentionality behind it, guiding the audience through stark tonal and thematic shifts. In one moment, you are laughing



with the characters, poking fun at the angsty preteen boy for growing a pair of cat ears, and the next you are sitting on the edge of your seat wondering how this small, young woman is going to fight a space alien robot monster the size of a skyscraper with nothing but her electric guitar.

Supporting the visuals is arguably one of the best received aspects of the series: the soundtrack. The series director, Kazuya Tsurumaki, had contacted his favorite band, The Pillows, in order to bring a fresh sound to the series that no other anime had⁴. Instead of focusing on drawn out orchestral scores, the studio wanted to feature something fresh, hip, and local so as to draw in their targeted crowd, that being teenagers and young adults. This is also why the dialogue is carried out so heavily by various pop culture references and quick pacing⁵.

2 FLCL, episode 1, "Fooly Cooly," dir. by Kazuya Tsurumaki and Masahiko Otsuka, aired on August 5, 2003, on Adult Swim.

3 FLCL, episode 5, "Brittle Bullet," dir. by Kazuya Tsurumaki and Shouki Saeki, aired on August 9, 2003, on Adult Swim.

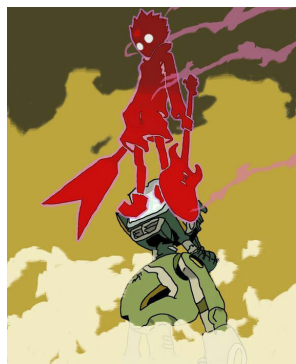
4 Carl Gustav Horn, "FLCL is the Formula," Pulp: The Manga Magazine, March 2002

5 Adam Wescot, "FLCL's English Translation was a Uniquely Tricky Process," /Film, Static Media, March 4, 2022, <https://www.slashfilm.com/788759/flcls-english-translation-was-a-uniquely-tricky-process/>.

The series draws you in with innovative visuals, unique sounds, and realistic dialogue, but where it really gripped me was the characters. The writing style of FLCL has a way of rapidly jumping from one plot to another without leaving time for explanation or connections



between them, which many have criticized. Even so, I believe this style truly shines when it comes to exploring character. Naota specifically is a compelling protagonist; he is an adolescent boy that dreads living in his older brother, Tasuku's, shadow, and he constantly expresses distaste for his new nickname Tak-kun which belonged to his brother before he left. Yet, at the same time, it's Tasuku whom Naota idolizes and wishes to be like. This ties in with Naota's views on adulthood, where he longs to be



an adult and seen as an individual with a voice that matters, and it's a conflict which I know that I personally have experienced: growing up with a brother close enough in age so that his shadow always overlapped mine, yet old enough to serve as a role model. It's specific scenarios like these that are capable of drawing in such a cult following; you receive a balanced mixture of fantasy and familiarity, and it makes you consider your own story.

To hammer down the point, it's Naota's perspective that matters most. It transports you, the audience, to that familiar place of hot, concrete summers sitting by the radio. You live through robotic transformations and catchy guitar riffs while the world slaps you in the face every time you think you finally understand. This is precisely how the series has captured the essence of adolescence, and ultimately, that's what FLCL is all about; it's a commentary about growing up and maturity rolled into a rowdy, artistic, science fiction explosion of action and mystery. And, peeling away the layers of inexplicable plot points and dramatic mood shifts, I have found the story of my own life written in the characters.

Rocket League and EDM

Camerin McManus

Rocket League is a car soccer game. You can jump, boost, and fly around the field in a car, all with the objective of scoring a ball into the opposing team's net. I started playing this game when I was around 13 years old. I was really bad in the beginning, struggling to even hit the ball. Yet two things kept me engaged: my friends and the music. I had a very bland music taste at the time, mostly consisting of music my parents listened to. However, this game introduced me to a new genre of music that I had never explored before. Electronic Dance Music. When you first load into the game, you are put into the menu screen, and the game plays the "Rocket League playlist." It wasn't your average game playlist, playing popular songs of the era, it was playing music created specifically for the game. What caught my attention was how cohesive this music felt to the game. When I would load up the game, I would hear these songs, fast-paced, upbeat, and polished. It would get me excited to play. When playing the game, you have the music in the background (normally the music wouldn't play during gameplay, but I had changed a setting so it would), and when you're playing well, the music just matched the feeling of being in a flow state so well it was addicting. Even at times when I would play badly and think about getting off, that one song would start playing, and it would change my mindset. I would feel more energetic and excited, inspired by the music and ready to jump into the next game.

When Rocket League first came out, it was a small indie sequel to Supersonic Acrobatic Rocket-Powered Battle-Cars. SARPBC saw very mild success when it first came out, it failed to grow due to janky mechanics and lackluster gameplay. So when Rocket League came out, they had a very small budget. They worked

with independent artists to create the music for the game. This led to a one-of-a-kind feel to the game. None of the music in the game could you hear anywhere else but in Rocket League. They continued this style of creating music for the game until 2017, when they paired with the label Monstercat, a Canadian label most well known for EDM. This partnership helped cement Rocket League and its relationship to the EDM genre, bringing more well-known artists such as Deadmouse5, TokyoMachine, ViceTone, Slushie, Tristam & Bracken, and Droeloe. The Monstercat and Rocket League collaboration helped keep the game feeling fresh and new while also allowing players to be in a shared community of music, making the game feel alive and exciting with each new season.

Rocket League really shaped my music taste. Due to the competitive nature of the game, the soundtrack encouraged that feeling. Its fast-paced and upbeat nature makes you feel focused, and when you play well, euphoric. It then attaches these great feelings to not only the specific songs but to the music genre as well. Due to this simple collaboration of a music genre and a game, I believe it led my life in many ways by creating this connection to EDM music. After listening to all of the songs included in the game too many times, I started to branch out into the music genre, diving deeper and finding new artists to listen to. Without this game, I would have never thought to dive into the EDM genre. But because I have, I made great friendships with people, which would not have happened without Rocket League. One of my best friends and I will be going to an EDM music festival this summer, all because this game introduced me to one of my favorite genres of music and helped me understand why people love electronic music.

Without this connection to EDM music, I don't know if I would have gotten so into music and sound the way I have today. There are multiple producers and artists that have inspired me to create art that come from the EDM genre, Fred again, and Flume are two of my favorites. They inspire me to create better and better sound design while also trying to tap into people's emotions, creatively add synthesis, explore the world of sound, and experiment. As silly

as it might sound, this simple car soccer game influenced who I am today and what I aspire to be, all because of their choice of soundtrack. My world today is sound, and many of my inspirations come from EDM and EDM artists. Without Rocket League, I really am unsure if I would have ever ended up exploring the genre as much as I have. This genre of music has led me to explore other genres of music as well, expanding my taste and understanding of music and sound altogether. This then led me to make music, which then led me to explore sound design, then synthesis, etc. All this because of a video game that introduced me to some weird-sounding music I hadn't heard before.

-
1. to, Contributors. 2017. "Rocket League X Monstercat." Monstercat Wiki. Fandom, Inc. 2017. https://monstercat.fandom.com/wiki/Rocket_League_x_Monstercat.
 2. to, Contributors. 2024. "Soundtrack." Rocket League Wiki. Fandom, Inc. 2024. <https://rocketleague.fandom.com/wiki/Soundtrack>.
 3. Megluno. 2025. "The Music That Made Rocket League Legendary ." YouTube. August 19, 2025. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sfm2pJc3E7w>.

Diamandra's Mirror

G.A.AA

It's a hot day, the sun is scorching, the air conditioning is blaring, slowly becoming white noise, out the window all there is to see is the heat waves seemingly coming out the concrete. If I were to step outside barefoot, my feet would be fried like an egg sizzling on a greased up pan. Sometimes on days like this I find myself thinking that the world isn't worth exploring. I wear a tank top, no bra, shorts, hair tied because I got annoyed at the heat pocket being created with it down and I'm on my way to the fridge to feel the cool air. Days like that, hot summer days, made me feel eternal, but it also takes me back to the few memories I have of my family's home country. That's where the rest of my extended family are, back in West Africa in a country so small that it tends to get overshadowed by bigger countries like Ghana and Nigeria. I'm reminded of that place whenever I smell the lingering scents of summer, whether it's the smell of grilled corn, roasted peanuts, fire wood, and even Anime.

Anime and I go way back, we've been together since I was 8 years old on my Ipad Mini in a room I shared with my sister. It's been with me through various moments of my life and was the best way for me to immerse myself into worlds unlike my own, but never at any point would I have thought it would take me back to my memories of back home. An anime, not even based in West Africa, but loosely in Brazil¹ made me nostalgic for something I haven't been around in so long. After finally finishing it years later, I still

1 "Brazilian Beats and Bad Ass Babes: Introducing Michiko to Hatchin." Editorial. Sabukaru. Accessed April 17, 2026. <https://sabukaru.online/articles/brazilian-beats-and-bad-ass-babes-introducing-michiko-to-hatchin>.

find myself mesmerized by it. It was a representation that wasn't just skin deep, but had more to it with what it had to say, though I can't say that that's where my focus was placed on when watching Michiko and Hatchin. There was just something about the world and its people that had me in my seat more than the growing bond between the two female protagonists.

The backgrounds show beautiful scenery on some occasions, making the locations the pair visit seem like a tourist destination², but on other occasions the backgrounds showed the reality of the place they lived in. A gritty place with homes and businesses with paint on their walls peeling and chipping because not many can afford the up keep, living in an impoverished environment where one wrong encounter with the wrong person could result in death, area's being gang controlled in a way where the police can't do much about. I can't say that my mother's country has one to one issues with the show, but they're definitely similar. The last time I remembered going was during the summer with my sister just before I went into 7th grade at a new school. I don't remember much about the flight besides it being long and the smell of reheated curry at my seat with an unfolded table and I can't say I remember after the plane. What I do remember is when we finally waved down a taxi, but instead of a yellow cab, it was a black SUV. My sister took the initiative to chat it up with my Aunt as she directed the driver to my grandmother's house, I however, chose to allocate my time to look at the window to see the new environment I would be staying in for the month.

As we passed by business and homes I noticed the sparse patches of grass and was greeted to the orangey-red clay ground. The homes and shops were made of concrete, but tattered and worn with rigid metal roofing that were at different levels of rust. Tree diversity was minimal, but the few that were there were tall proud coconut trees. There were many people walking, cars driving and motorcyclists acting as fast taxis to get people where they needed to go. All crammed into the city square and seeing Michiko and Hatchin explore areas not so dissimilar to my own was magical. I could see my family's home being portrayed in the background environment of this show. Shop keepers having plasticky chairs

2 Deleted User. "[Spoilers][Essay] How well Michiko To Hatchin represents Brazil?." Reddit, 2017. Accessed April 17, 2026.

outside their store or restaurant and pop vendors trying to sell things from homemade goods to commercially available toiletries. It was honestly shocking to see two different places be so similar.

Even though I wouldn't say there's much of a gang issue in the place where my family comes from, poverty is still a problem³. Far too often things happen to people just trying to live their lives, but life doesn't always work out in their favor. In episode 4, "Stray Cat Milky Way", there is a nightclub dancer, Pepê Lima and her younger sister, Lulu, needing money to get out of the poor situation and attempt to rob Michiko and Hatchin after a night of drinking⁴. The two sisters find out that the protagonists have nothing on them, so they resort to stealing from Rico, Pepê's boss and boyfriend. By the end of the episode, Lulu is being chased by young boys who Rico formed as his own little gang, her fate being left unknown. Pepê goes on to try and save her, only to be greeted by the same little boys, a gun pointed directly at her and all she can do is resign to her fate. Years back I heard about my Uncle's brother passing because of a hit and run. His brother and a friend were walking along the road when a car suddenly hit him and ran off without stopping to check the situation. I've heard stories from my Grandmother on how people had died because of government blatant cruelty and high police corruption⁵. Is my home better now? Even google only knows so much and I'm not local, but that aside there's a tragedy in this being "how life goes" where frustration is only there as a passing moment to then be let go because there is nothing else that could quite be done.

Being in a place that feels like it can only provide a person with hardship isn't the easiest thing to survive. Everyday is important and tomorrow can be a blur, so in a place like that what can you do

3 . Bailey, Ellen. "Togo." Editorial. EBSCO. Last modified 2025. Accessed April 21, 2026.<https://www.ebsco.com/research-starters/geography-and-cartography/togo>.

4 Michiko & Hatchin. Directed by Sayo Yamamoto. Written by Takashi Ujita. Aired October 15, 2008, on Manglobe. + Michiko & Hatchin. Directed by Sayo Yamamoto. Screenplay by Takashi Ujita. 2008. Manglobe, Shochiku, 2013. Blu-ray disc.

5 BBC. "Togo Country Profile." British Broadcasting Corporation. Last modified May 21, 2024. Accessed April 21, 2026. <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-africa-14106781>.

besides live in it while you still can. Take in everyday and enjoy what you have and not everyday will be a good day, but there should be room to celebrate. Often I find that in the music being played. On a cool night, where most shops were closed, but the bars were still open, the windows of shops lighting the path more than a dim street light, I was with my sister and my cousin and we were headed somewhere. One of the store's radios were on and played a song that I knew and, in a rare moment, I let myself go. My heart was beating, I felt the rhythm of the beats in my finger and I sang along. Usually I'm more reserved, so this isn't something they were expecting to see from me. Music, dance, celebration, even if it's as simple as humming, gives way to the feeling of freedom. Even the music of Michiko and Hatchin does that. Everytime I hear the opening score I want to get up out of my seat and dance. Jazz and samba music is like an invitation to let yourself go and the music throughout the whole show is the same. It's a hand that reaches out to you when you're on the ground. Now everytime I smell the scent of summer I think of Michiko and Hatchin and in turn to my family's home country and through that I feel nostalgic, but also eternal, like a hot humid summer day.

"The Story of Paul Dupla"

Gabe

Project Zomboid is an immersive hardcore zombie game where the end goal is to tell a story. The whole purpose is to die; there is no way of avoiding it. Days become harder as the dead multiply, supplies diminish, and the looming doom of winter ever-becoming stronger. There is no end-game boss, no currency, no safe-zones. This paper explores one of the many stories that was created in a playthrough through the eyes of the character rather than player.

The character we pilot is Perry Dupla: a stoner kid struggling to hold on to his humanity during the apocalypse. Frank Agama Perez plays the character of Sp'higé Geh'äir, aka Spikehead Lee, a punk with an interest in fitness that has a heart of gold. Then comes Thomas, aka Geez, played by Joe Crighton, who is an older war-hardened veteran that leads the group.

This is the start of the apocalypse, and the story of how Perry Dupla dies.

DAY 1

HOLY **SHIT** what the fuck is going on. Like, genuinely, what the fuck? Why is this happening right now, out of all the days and time in my sober years; a fucking zombie apocalypse in the middle of my high while I'm watching my goddamn cooking show. There's already so many of them outside, how did I not notice anything?? How long has it been since the outbreak started? It couldn't have been more than a few hours...but how are there **ALREADY SO MANY OF THEM?**

Fuck. Fuck, fuck fuck *fuck*. They haven't noticed me yet, but I can't stay here. I'm supposed to meet Spikehead Lee at the bar today... I don't know what else to do but go there and figure everything else out later. Service is out already and I don't know where anyone else could be. I just hope he's alive, because if he's not then I'm double fucked. I have nothing to defend myself with, either; I just fucking moved here! Whatever. I'm just gonna pray to whatever God there is that they don't notice me leaving...

But I'm going to finish my show first. At the lowest volume possible.

9:05PM



I killed my neighbor. I took his watch. I killed so many already.

The gamble paid off: Lee was there... but everyone else in the bar was infected except this one old guy that Lee was hiding behind. He seems to know what he's doing, which is scary as fuck because how are you okay with this? With any of this? He's killed as much as I have, from what I've seen at least, and he's taking it a lot fucking better than I am. Already telling us what to do and turning this bar into a barricade, organizing their storage with the things we've looted from bodies. From people. He must've been a veteran or some shit—it looks like he's killed before.

I can only be grateful for him since Lee is doing the worst out of all of us. Useless. But I should've known, he's a fucking pacifist for fucks sake; wouldn't hurt a fly. Of course I'd be stuck with him for a god damn apocalypse. So far I haven't seen him deal any final blows, at most he's been pushing them back and he almost got got because of it until the old dude stepped in. We'd be cooked if it weren't for this geezer.

We just finished dragging the bodies into a pile outside of the bar. So many people that I could've been friends with in another life... if it weren't for a fuckass scientist somewhere in the world. I'm made out of rotten-flesh-scented sweat right now while Lee's prissy ass has been washing off in the sink this whole time. ~~Washing off the blood of the people that I killed.~~ I shouldn't be mad at him for wanting to feel a little normal right now. God knows water will be a luxury worth dying  for once the city's power runs out.

I also found a CD in  someone's pocket. It was some sort of recording from a Christian radio  station that they saved. I managed to take my PortaDisc  and some headphones from home before heading to the bar, so I can listen to it in my free time...

I'm not religious, but now is a good time to think about it.

However, if there is a God out there that would allow this to happen...I would ask for forgiveness for the blood on my hands if you weren't a killer yourself.

~~I wouldn't mind if I didn't wake up tomorrow.~~

KILL COUNT: 4

Rest in Peace Roger Walkman. Took his watch.

Guy with a cool looking mohawk.

Lee talked to him before shit went down.

Man with a backpack.

Policeman. Gave the gun to the boomer.

DAY 2 | 10:00PM

This journaling thing is the only thing that's really keeping me sane right now... something to look forward to at the end of the day. It feels like it's been a week already, but thanks to Roger's watch it's been keeping me grounded; it's only been a day since my last entry. I don't even know why I took it... fight or flight, maybe? I'm just glad I did. I didn't think it would've helped me this much. It even has the weather and date on it. Miss you, Rogers. (and thank you)

The old man still hasn't shared his name either... he's not much of a talker unless it's to bark orders at us. Regardless if he shares it or not, I'm calling him Geez. Normally I wouldn't give a fuck about what he says, but I'd be stupid not to follow his lead even if I don't know what it's for. He told us to loot the surrounding area and mentioned that the bar was a good place to set up "base" since it's close to other convenient shit.

There was a grocery and convenience store that we looted, Lee and I got all the chips (+4 🍟) and I drank a whole liter of soda down the hatch (Geez, seemed 🤨 annoyed lol). We got a couple of weapons and tools (🔪 Hacksaw + Hammer) there, too. We also noted a junkyard full of cars across the bar that could be handy later, but there were too many zombies people there to try something today.



Geez and I had to kill some of them that were too close to the bar. They were a group of three women. They had some nice outfits on and it looked like they were about to go out and do something fun together. I don't remember their faces.

It's been fucking tough, and I can tell it's getting worse for Lee. We've been trying to keep morale up for each other by trying to act like shit is normal in the little details. He's always been competitive and fit as hell so he tries to race me everywhere we go, he challenges me in random fitness checks like push-ups and burpees, and I've been trying to peer-pressure him into smoking. It worked, but he immediately hated it. Don't know whether to be happy or worried that he did...there's not a lot of things to help calm nerves right now, to be fair. I just want a distraction for him.

He's even been trying to read; he's not great at that. I can tell that he just wants an escape and has been grasping at anything he could find to get it. It's making me feel awful. I've been collecting magazines ( , ) and shit for him every time I go out, I found some games too  ! Still working on trying to get a compatible device to play them on... I can surprise him with it, it shouldn't be too hard.

I even shared my Christian CD with him. I'm not sure what religion Geez affiliates himself with, but I played it out loud for everyone after I realized how quiet it was without my headphones. It might get annoying since it'll keep repeating the same thing, but it's noise at least. To my surprise, Geez only told me to turn it down a little but he seemed to be listening to it when he was taking furniture down.

I still don't know what his deal is, but he seems to be opening up a little more, especially after seeing how depressed Lee has been lately. I'd peg him to preach some masculinity bullshit to him about how he's being a pussy, but instead, he offered him a beer and basically did what I pegged him for, but in a gentler way. It didn't seem to help Lee that much, but he seemed grateful either way.

Geez's name is Thomas. He said he always wanted a kid.

KILL COUNT: 2

Two women. They seemed to be friends.

DAY 3 | 6:43 PM

Resting before I head out for tonight; today has been more of the same so there's not much to write right now. Lee seems to be getting worse though...he's been doing a shitton of push-ups and has been staying in the base for most of the day trying his hardest to learn how to fish from a book  he got at some house, despite being basically illiterate. The magazines aren't helping him either. Maybe I can be on the lookout for some anti-depressants?

Anyway, Thomas did find some keys to an ambulance for us. Never would have thought that I'd be riding in an ambulance while I'm not the one they're escorting to a hospital. We can move things around more and maybe even leave this place if we need to! Thomas did say that it's a temporary car to have since this one screams for attention, and it's a good point. We looked over at the junkyard and saw that it was mostly clear, so that's where we're heading right now, to see if there is a more low-key ride.

I've never mentioned this detail before, but outside of the bar sits a good condition blue Chevalier Cossette. Sexy ass car, god I want it so bad, but we can't find the keys anywhere!! I need to learn how to hotwire a car somehow, it would've saved us a trip from possibly killing anyone else...or being killed, too.

I'll update once we get back.

2:01 AM

I got bit.

DAY 4 | 2:00 PM

So fucking stupid. I can't believe that happened to me. I didn't have the energy to write it down last night because I basically almost fucking bled to death. Right on the throat, too. I don't know how I didn't hear her... It was a foggy night, I was too busy looking at a distance when she snuck up on me.

Obviously, I'm still me right now. I woke up queasy as fuck, probably from the lost of blood though, but other than that, I don't feel anything...weird. Just weak; so I'm taking it slow. I guess I'm basically a science experiment now. I slept in the closet, away from the others, strapped down by my waist so that it's somewhat comfortable for me to lay down at least. Lee checked on me throughout the night and changed my bandages once it got too bloody.

Ironically, I think Lee should've been strapped down more than me: that boy couldn't stop doing push-ups in the middle of the night. He was so restless. I luckily had some painkillers to help me go to sleep, so I probably had more sleep than the guy. He must've been doing it all night because he was sweaty as hell and out of breath when I woke up.

Lee's behavior is starting to get really worrisome that Thomas pulled me aside and suggested that a little joy ride around the neighborhood might help cheer him up; we could even pull a couple of hordes out of the way. Sure old man, let's just wake up the whole county and have them chase us in broad daylight. What's the worst that could happen?

Although I have been wanting to sound those alarms...

5:52 PM

This is the end of the line for me. I'm sorry to those I've killed, and to Thomas for leaving him all alone.

Lee turned. He was infected this whole time. Probably since the beginning, back while we were trying to take control of the bar. We were doomed from the start, but I should have known... he wasn't acting like himself. In my defense though, how can anyone right now?

It all happened so fast, I don't exactly know what happened. I was talking to him, mostly rambling about things and when I finally looked at him for the first time since driving, his eyes were glossed over. I crashed into a cemetery, out of all places. There was already a horde building up from the sirens blasting.

Amidst all the chaos, I found a place to rest. Just for a little while, at least. It won't be long before one of them finds me, but I want to cherish these last moments of being human as much as I can.

I'm grateful for the pain in my lungs.

I'm grateful for the static I feel in the soles of my feet.

I'm grateful to feel.

I have more painkillers in my bag. I'm going to take all of them, smoke a joint, eat whatever is left of my burrito 🌯, and hopefully get a nap in before I wake up to whatever's next for me.

Thomas, if you ever find this: it wasn't your fault. Thank you for everything, man.

Escapism

Grayson Carter

Have you ever loved something so dearly that you simply couldn't accept that it was done? In my opinion, the best endings are always bittersweet, even if they aren't intended to be. The more satisfying a story wraps up, the more unsatisfying it feels to put down the story, that world you've grown to love. When a story ends, you're being forced to make a choice; put down the story, accept it for how it is and move on, or you don't. It seems a little ridiculous not to move on, right? But there are some times where that's impossible. The reason that 'fandom' is even a thing in the first place, is that damned dissatisfaction after it's all over. It draws people together to discuss, create, well beyond the time that the story was first made.

There are some people who aren't ever able to leave the world they've entered into. After the release of Avatar in 2009, there were lots of people, mostly on Avatar fan forums, who started posting about feeling unsatisfied with their lives. There were so many who adored James Camreon's beautiful planet of Pandora and the Na'vi people that became depressed when they had to leave the theater and come back to the real world, that it became actual observable phenomena. There were even people who wrote about contemplating suicide in order to be re-born into a world similar to Pandora. PADS, or Post-Avatar Depression Syndrome is the official but not medically recognized term for this. There are just some people who will never be satisfied with coming back to their day-to-day lives after experiencing something they consider better than reality.

Avatar may have caused a small depression, but for most of

the people in the Avatar forums, the movie caused them to find community, comradery and for some fans, love.

This world means so much to so many people, it causes people to change, find friends, create communities, even though it isn't real. My Grandma was one of these fans, something about the world of Avatar tugged at her heart so strongly, that she wanted to be reincarnated as a Na'vi in Pandora, was almost convinced of it even. Believing this brought her a sense of peace; These fantasy worlds, as fictitious as they are, have the ability to bring out the strongest emotions in all kinds of people.

Deltarune is a game where in the boring old town they live in, and the same boring people, exists a world below that is parallel to the one above. Where there's only darkness. So much darkness that you can't tell what's fake and what's real. That the inanimate objects of the real world start to move and take on personalities in this darkness. After everything is darker than dark, a Dark World is created where you are able to use magic, fight magical enemies, and make friends with various colorful characters in the Dark World. You are unable to bring anything or anyone with you from the Dark Worlds, since they are all just objects in the real world. All the friends you make, all the memories you create, all the Dark Worlds you explore, none of it can come back with you into the Light since none of it is actually real. The primary goal of Deltarune is to seal all the Dark Worlds inside of your town, and stop the person responsible for creating them.

These Dark Worlds are fantastical and anything better than the normal one. Alas, they must be shut down. If they aren't sealed, and more dark worlds continue to pop-up, the world will be overrun by darkness and eventually everything, dark and light, will be swallowed up whole. Despite the risk though, from our main characters' perspective, it just doesn't make sense to let all the dark worlds disappear. The connections they've made are far too important to just let go. One of the residents of the dark, Ralsei, is your close friend who accompanies you on all your dark world adventures. Although he cannot follow you into the world of the light, that just makes it more difficult to do what must be done

in order to finish this journey. They find much more comfort with the idea of the adventure simply never ending, as impossible of a goal that may seem. Although the story of Deltarune has yet to fully conclude, this aspect of our character's motivations will not remain unaddressed and I can almost conclude that forcing this option in some way will be something that is yet to come. A way to make sure the journey is a never-ending one.

Deltarune has heavy ties to the idea of fate and a predestined path, as the journey our characters will take is written solidly in the lines of fate. Breaking fate and carving your own path in order to have a journey that never ends, a story that doesn't end at the ending. A way to keep the dark world alive, to carry on the people and places you've become attached to throughout the adventure. Fans take the love that they have for characters and worlds that only exist temporarily, and make sure that their stories never end. In their minds, these worlds find a home to stay.

The Lost Japanese Island

Melissa Delaney + Jake Mullins

Hyokkori Gourd Island is a puppet show musical created by Hisashi Inoue. The show was broadcasted on the Japanese broadcast station, NHK, from April 6th 1964 to April 4th 1969. Gourd Island became an island because of a piece of land that split away from the main land because of a massive volcanic eruption. Ms. Sunday and the students, Doctor, Teke, Dump, and Chappi were on the field trip when the eruption happened. They tried to escape the



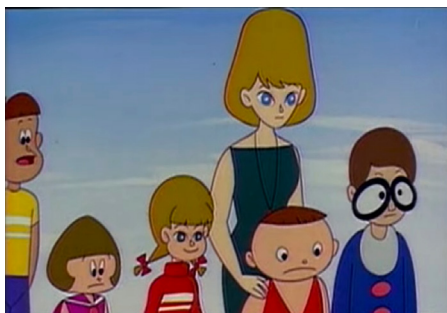
eruption and while on the bridge, the bridge split in half causing Gourd island to drift away into the ocean. Many characters join the crew like Machine Gun Dandy, a Chicago gangster escapes from a prisoner airplane. The pirate, Torahige crashes his pirate ship onto the island by accident. Don Gabacho, the president of another country

is forcefully pushed out of a television by the news reporters, and he becomes the leader over Gourd Island.

Due to the success of the puppet show, a movie was put into production by Toei Animation who are well known for making Sailor Moon, Dragon Ball, Digimon and One Piece. In collaboration with NHK, the animated film was a recreation of the second arc of the puppet show the Burdokia Kingdom. The Burdokia Kingdom is about Gourd Island crashing onto a city filled with dogs who despise humans because of previous experiences in contact with humans.

It is really hard to watch this film until recently because the movie has never received a home media release due to complications with NHK and Toei. Just recently, a Mandarin dub of the movie was found which no one knew existed because it was under a different name. Because of that there are not a lot of accessible resources online, however there are books that discuss the story and it's reportedly very similar to the film.

The story of the film is similar to the first episode of the show when we meet the cast of characters previously mentioned on a field trip where the land separates causing Gourd island to form. Later on, they accidentally travel to the city of Budokia that is filled with dogs. The self-proclaimed leader of



Gourd Island, Don Gabacho, tries to reason with the leader of the Budokia Kingdom. However, Secretary of Defense Pitts ends up capturing Don Gabacho. So, the Gourd Island residents disguise themselves as horses to retrieve Don Gabacho, and it succeeds. Afterwards, the Gourd Island citizens fight back against the dogs, and the dogs eventually surrender since they were losing. However, Secretary Pitts refuses to surrender, and he fights by himself with Machine Gun Dandy. Machine Gun Dandy ends up winning, and the Burdokia Kingdom becomes a land where humans and humanoid dogs can live in peace. The Gourd Island cast returns to the island and drifts away into the big ocean ahead.

Because of the length of the movie a lot of materials were removed from the original puppet show such as songs, characters and the story. In the movie, it is condensed down to 60 minutes removing a decent amount of the story and songs and the characters in the film who were switched to match the current cast of the show in 1967. The reason why this film is very important is because it is the first collaboration with NHK and Toei. Because of the ambition of the original puppet show having 1224 episodes a lot of episodes are forever gone due to reusing tapes to save costs. Only 8 episodes

survive from the show and it is very hard to watch them without a DVD that was released in 2003. The Toei Gourd Island film is the only way to access anything close to footage from the original Burokia Kingdom arc.

This series is very important to Japanese culture and the people living in Japan during the mid to late 1960s. Don Gabacho the aforementioned character from Gourd Island has a lot of flaws like being a hindrance to the cast, causing the conflict in some arcs and can be egotistical. However his song “Don Gabacho’s faith of the future”, when the crew of



characters was in a really bad spot in the story, Don Gabacho would sing this song. “If today doesn’t work, tomorrow will work, if the day after tomorrow doesn’t work then the day after that will. No matter where I am, there’s always a tomorrow to look forward to!” Swung a lot of peoples hearts who lived in Japan especially after people still recovering from World War II.

—

1. NHK. “ひょっこりひょうたん島 制作者座談会.” ひょっこりひょうたん島 制作者座談会 | 番組 | NHKアーカイブス, 2009. <https://www2.nhk.or.jp/archives/articles/?id=C0010427>.

2. NHK. Hyokkori Gourd Island–The Land of Dogs, the Kingdom of Burdokia, August 1964.

3. Hyokkori Gourd Island: The Woof Woof Riots. B-77, March 15 1965.

4. NHK. “ひょっこりひょうたん島.” ひょっこりひょうたん島 | 番組 | NHKアーカイブス, April 16, 2010. <https://www2.nhk.or.jp/archives/articles/?id=C0010621>.

5. Ito, Satoru. Hyotan Island, You Can See Tomorrow: 10 Hints to Change the Future with Gabacho. Bungeisha, 2003.

6. Hisashi Inoue. The Volume on Burdokia. Vol. 1-3. 3 vols. Chikuma Shobo Co., Ltd, January 1991.

“Enter Lil’ Slugger”

Julia Velazquez

In a lifestyle where age brings responsibility and feelings that seem too overbearing for an innocent person to handle, escape is easy to imagine. It’s easy to think of anywhere else you’d rather be, to daydream about a future with little work and high pay, and to pretend your to-do list isn’t now long enough to scroll through. Yet when we look at recent popular media, fictional characters are often depicted to be having fun in their day-to-day lives, where their adventures take up more screen time than their idle work. It is almost like the TV is mocking us, showing us what life could be like if we just tried a bit harder, made more friends, and focused on love more than achievements. The stories we grow immersed with on the screen sometimes feel even more important than our true mundane daily routines.

So when *Paranoia Agent* was released, a thirteen episode anime directed by Satoshi Kon, its abstractness and non-linear structure was almost repulsive in comparison to the multi-season colorful, action packed dramas viewers were used to. While there is a main protagonist, Tsukiko Sagi, she feels distant from the show, only appearing once in a while and mentioned in passing. Each episode follows a different person with a completely different life from the previous and next episode. The only trait they have in common is the fact that they’re victims of Lil’ Slugger, a young boy with golden skates and a baseball bat, crooked from its impact on his previous targets. This unique cast lineup makes it hard for the audience to grow attached to any one character or follow along with a particular storyline to cheer on.

While this distance might be intentional, a way for the viewers to really hone in on the situation itself rather than fan over any one

character or relationship, it works in an immersive way unique to this show. Each episode feels like the viewer is there in the city, following the investigation on who Lil' Slugger is and how anyone could possibly catch him, or perhaps even like the viewer is living vicariously through the main character in an episode. For example, in episode eight, "Happy Family Planning", it feels just as jarring to watch the audio cut out while a man suddenly throws himself in front of an oncoming subway train as the characters there witnessing it feel. In episode three, "Double Lips", it's easy for the audience to be just as confused as Harumi Chono is about her split personality, struggling to decipher which person she is as the episode progresses. Satoshi Kon does a fantastic job at keeping the deep immersion intact, having the audience feel relatability in an abstract sense rather than a literal way.

It's relatable in the way that viewers feel upset in the same ways as the characters do, they're scared of the unknown in the same way the characters are, and they seek answers just as badly as the cast does. Paranoia Agent is a wonderful project that explores the sense of self, wanting to understand one's place in society, and what it's like to feel like an outcast. Even being a show with a debut date in 2004, the human emotions and feeling of society pressure is displayed in a very relevant way to now in 2026. People are still disturbed by the process of confrontation, struggle to find a name for themselves, and feel overwhelmed by guilt and responsibility. In this way, Paranoia Agent successfully captures its audience's attention and emotions by both maintaining a complex storyline and non-linear narrative while also sending a relatable message that people with an acute awareness of their sense of self can pick apart.

The show's grand twist arrives in episode thirteen, the last episode, rightly titled, "The Final Episode". Although somewhat ambiguously, Lil' Slugger is revealed to be a figment of Tsukiko Sagi's unconscious. The baseball bat wielding character himself is completely made up, and is used as a form of release from societal pressure, responsibility, and guilt. It is essentially an excuse to fall back on to avoid the harsh truth of reality.

The concept itself is abstract and hard to understand in the grand scheme of things. When looking back on the entire series, it

makes viewers wonder what was real and what wasn't, if anyone was actually assaulted by Lil' Slugger and faced any sort of repercussions, and if the detectives' investigation was completely useless in the end or if it even happened at all.

Cuphead: The Battle of Katnip Kollege

Katy Kunberger

Disclaimer: This is a work of crossover fanfiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are owned by Studio MDHR and Warner Bros.

'Twas a fine day at Inkwell Isles, Cuphead, Mugman and Miss Chalice were walking into the forest singing some jazz tunes. "Look!" Cuphead yelled, "A car! Let's drive to a fun place!" "Hold your horses, Cuphead!" Mugman paused Cuphead, "Let's make sure that the car is not broken down." So, the three kids walked to the car and there was a key inside the ignition. Someone has abandoned the car. So, Cuphead turned on the car and the car was working! But – the car is floating above the ground! "Is that a flying car?" Miss Chalice asked Cuphead in a baffled tone. "Oh my, yes, it is!" Cuphead exclaimed "It's obviously floating above the ground!" Within a few seconds, the car shot up into the air. The flying car flew above Inkwell Isles and throughout the sky. The kids were so excited. They pretended that they were on a long carnival ride – until the car was acting up. Unfortunately, the car fell down and it crashed! The car crashed down into an unfamiliar place well outside of Inkwell Isles.

Fortunately, the kids are still alive and feeling okay. However, once they landed into that unfamiliar place, they noticed an old school across from the destroyed car. Cuphead walked towards the old school and he thought it was a cute little abandoned school where he, Mugman and Miss Chalice can play around at. But that was not the case! As the kids walked into the school, they noticed that there were nothing but cats! They were cat students. "Cuphead!" Mugman shrieked "We battled with cats before! We gotta get out of there!" So, Mugman rushed to the school telephone and called the emergency number but the phone was not going through. Soon enough, there was a black cat

student with a bowler hat and a green and black shirt and gray plaid pants. His name was Melvin and he came up and mugged Mugman. "We only allow cats in Katnip Kollege!" Melvin yelled. Cuphead and Miss Chalice screamed bloody murder. Mugman was not scared to battle with the students in Katnip Kollege. So, he used his special shooting powers and attempted to shoot the cats. Melvin grabbed a battle axe from the wall and battled Mugman. Two more cats, Calvin and Kitty attacked Cuphead and Miss Chalice. The other cats launched in and the whole school was in battle until a professor ran out of the hallway and he was out of his mind as soon he discovered the destruction.

"What have you done?!" the Professor gasped "Why did you all demolish the school?!" "Because the Devil told us to!" Melvin answered. "The Devil?!" Mugman exclaimed to Cuphead and Miss Chalice, "At Katnip Kollge?!" "You heard us right, kids" Kitty said "The Devil possessed us to attack!" "And he wanted your souls in hell!" Calvin told the harsh truth to the kids. "So, you're not really the bad guys?" Miss Chalice asked. "No, we were forced to take your souls but we didn't want to." Melvin cried "But if we didn't take them then we could go to hell!" "We are really sorry guys...we did not even know that." Cuphead sobbed. "It's not your fault, kids. It's the Devil's wrath that became his fault" Calvin remorsefully explained to Cuphead. "I made rainbow milkshakes for everyone!" Kitty brought in her milkshakes that she made at home. "Who wants them?" The kids raced to grab the milkshakes and they enjoyed them. The Professor even removed the evil souls out of the Katnip Kollege students, so they will not attack the kids anymore. The kids and the whole school went to the playground and played music and danced. Hopefully, the Devil will never find out.

A Recipe! Kitty Bright's Rainbow Milkshakes

Ingredients (To Make 15)

A Tub of Vanilla Ice Cream

A Pack of Rainbow Cookies

22.5 Cups of Whole Milk

Directions:

1. Scoop up three scoops of Vanilla Ice Cream
2. Pour the three scoops into a blender
3. Take out five Rainbow Cookies and break them into halves
4. Pour the cookie halves into the blender
5. Pour one and a half cups of Whole Milk
6. Stir the contents for 10 to 20 seconds
7. Turn on the blender and let it blend on medium until ready
8. Pour the milkshake into a cup
9. Repeat the same instructions for 14 more milkshakes
10. Serve all 15 of them and Bon Appetite!

The Golden Age of Looney Tunes: 1930s Musicals. May 31, 1991. VHS. MGM/UA Home Video.

"Katnip Kollege" is an animated musical short released on June 11, 1938 directed by Cal Howard and Cal Dalton. From the musical miniature "Dear Teacher" as the first song climbing up to the most massive hit, "As Easy as Rolling Off a Log" being the last song. The short has an all-star cast voicing the teenage / college-age cats. The vocal group, The Pied Pipers which had hit songs such as the 1944 hit song, "Dream". They debuted in "Katnip Kollege" as the jazz band singing the titular song. Johnny Cat and Kitty Bright are the lead couple of the cartoon. Decades later in February 2020; James Taylor recorded "As Easy as Rolling Off a Log" and it was somewhat a hit as well as the original song sung by Johnnie "Scat" Davis (Johnny Cat) and Mabel Todd (Kitty Bright).

"Cuphead on Steam." Steam, Studio MDHR, 29 Sept. 2017. store.steampowered.com/app/268910/Cuphead/.

"Cuphead" is an independent action video game released on September 29, 2017 created by Studio MDHR. The main characters are Cuphead and Mugman. But Miss Chalice was created later after the original release date. The Inkwell Isles were made up of different islands with each boss to attack. This video game was inspired by 1930s rubberhose cartoons from different animation studios such as Fleischer Studios, Warner Bros. and Disney.

“So how does the story of the wolf brothers end?”:

Luka Tenney

How is it you can look back at something from years ago, and find that nothing has changed? I don't mean in the way comforting nostalgia takes over you, I am talking about the haunting ire that comes when there has been no step forward, no progress. We are taught that change is the only constant, and yet I find myself revolted that we are at a standstill, if not a regression. You would think playing a game from nearly 10 years ago would feel like a time capsule or a blast to the past, so what do you do when it is a reflection of your current reality?

If you haven't been living under a rock or been blatantly closing your eyes to everything that has been happening in the US for the past decade then you should be aware of just how rampant racialized violence and hyper-nationalism has become in the US. This is the case now more than ever, with ICE agents roaming the streets, families getting ripped apart and shipped away, and America's growing count of police brutality cases. So when we look at a game from nearly a decade ago that depicts this same reality, what are we left to think other than that we must be trapped in our own cursed history?

Life is Strange 2 is the journey of two first-generation brothers trying to make it to their father's homeland after he was unjustly murdered by a cop. Along the way they are met with systemic racism, a manipulative religious cult, and a number of violent confrontations. Forced to grow up as fast as possible, Sean is tasked to take care of his little brother Daniel as they try to make it to Puerto Lobos, Mexico while also wrangling his brother's newfound telekinetic powers. Despite all of the hardships, the game focuses on brotherhood, love, and comfort.

I remember the moment I had finished *Life is Strange 2* and how I just sat there with a fire burning under my skin but also a feeling of hollowness. I had spent my run taking care of my little brother, teaching him how to use his powers and trying my damndest to keep this little kid safe and innocent in this violent world. I was certain I had reached the best ending of the game because I had protected Daniel at all costs, but what did that mean for Sean? To give his brother the best life possible he had to spend 15 years in jail for a crime he didn't commit, only to get out in a society that would never accept him and had only set him up to fail. What's even worse is that there is no truly good ending of the game, which is reflective of America's treatment of minorities.

In the other three endings, Sean is either separated from Daniel or killed in their attempts to get to Puerto Lobos. The most interesting ending to me as far as fan regard is the ending where they both make it to Puerto Lobos together, but are having to live with the dangers of life in Mexico. Many people saw this as the "good ending", they were both together and free. Yet, you can only achieve this ending if you tell Daniel to take care of you two above all else and let him do more reckless things rather than trying to protect him from the horrors of the world. Not to mention, Daniel has to kill a dozen cops to get there and when we finally see the brothers, neither is truly happy. They may be free from being unrightfully detained, but at the cost of their dreams and aspirations. Sean is now running a garage like his father had, despite him stating that's not what he wanted for himself. He had spent his time in Seattle thinking of his art and taking his time to figure things out. Now forced to do whatever can sustain a safer lifestyle for the brothers, Sean gives up on his art. Most heart-wrenchingly, we see Daniel forced into a life he didn't want and stripped of his childhood. In this route, Daniel has hurt many people and is stuck in Mexico, a place he never even wanted to flee to.

But what about the ending where you let Sean take the fall so Daniel can live a normal life? Well then we have to truly let Sean's life be ripped away from him. If we spend our time being a good

older brother, teaching Daniel how to control his powers and be careful of society then the only thing left to do is to give up the rest of Sean's life so Daniel can live his life as a normal kid. Even after being released from a 15 year sentence, Sean can't live a normal life, not in America. With an (unjust) criminal record, Sean will be left with less job opportunities and even more prejudice than before. When we see the brothers reunion, Daniel is talking to Sean and all Sean can do is break down. He missed so much of Daniel's life, Hell his own life, and now he's thrust back into a life he never was given time to adjust to. There is something to be said about the "Good Ending" resulting in the sacrifice of Sean's life so Daniel can live a normal one. Why is it that for Daniel to be the most happy Sean has to spend years paying for this crime? I have seen people be upset that this route is called "Redemption" because Sean had done nothing to need redemption. He had spent his entire time protecting Daniel and raising him to be a morally upstanding person, so why did he need redemption? Personally, I believe this meant that Sean was redeeming himself by being there for his brother, which he hadn't been at the beginning of the game which is what sparked the tragedy.

I wanted a good ending for these brothers after all the pain and strife they've experienced, but after looking at this game they realistically wouldn't be given one. Not because they don't deserve a happy ending, but because America demonizes Hispanic communities to such a degree that the writers would have to set aside reality for a conclusion viewers would enjoy, disregarding their own message. These brothers can't have a happy ending because America is rooted in systemic racism that stems from its colonialist history. It is heartbreaking that after being beaten down, shot at, witnessing their father's murder, and a slew of racially motivated hate crimes, these two boys can't live a peaceful life together. Yet, it is still the very reality that we have been stuck in even before Trump's spark of hypernationalism and xenophobia.

Once we step out of the game itself we can find that the reviews are not much safer, as they are filled with their own real world displays of prejudice. What is most irksome about this game is the close-mindedness that many of the reviews hold, which is what gives this game such a bad reputation. After scrolling through

the reviews there is an overwhelming regard that the depictions of racism were over-exaggerated and the game made the white characters villainized.



Two posts in the discussion section of the game on Steam. Figure A is of a developer clarifying the way political discussions should be handled. Figure B is a locked post, displaying the types of negative reviews that are given to this game, particularly one that finds the racist depictions to be over-exaggerative.

🔒 This topic has been locked



Direclaw ▾ May 6, 2023 @ 4:30pm ♀ 19

The level of political propaganda in this game is just scary.

The game just started, and we already have a family of nationalist neighbors, with american flags and everything, that just happen to be racist, aggressive and unreasonable. We then proceed to an encounter with a trigger-happy cop who just shoots unarmed people with their hands in the air.

Soon after that, another encounter with a crazy racist, nationalist, guy who just kidnaps children because they are the wrong color. There is not even an option to show to the guy that you did purchase the items he accuses you of shoplifting. The guy even goes on about building a wall and stuff, and we then get saved by a stereotypical leftist blogger, who is very much into politics, and says that everything is political...

I understand a certain level of politics creeping into writing. The writers are human after all, we all have our biases. But the level of dehumanization of the writer's political opponents is on the level of war time propaganda.

I think a large part of this is because some people don't want to face their own bigotry and the other is that people haven't been on the receiving end of racism. Every racist depiction in the game is something that I have seen on the news, Hell, there's even worse than what is present in the game happening today. So the idea that these depictions are out of touch with reality is far out of line. People don't want to talk politics when it's something that makes them uncomfortable or sits a little too close to home. Yet when the review section of the game has to be policed because people are saying that the depictions are "on the level of war time propaganda" or throwing insults without engaging in meaningful discussions it is truly telling. Never once did the depictions stand out to me as something unrealistic or highly-exaggerated. If anyone cut on a reputable news source they would see that every example of racism in the game is something that has been covered in real life. While not every negative review is a critique on the depictions of racism with underlying bias, it is quite a concerning amount of them.

-
1. AionMyWay. "Relationship Comparison between Max and Chloe and Sean and Daniel – Life Is Strange." YouTube, June 20, 2020. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kKGNIWbQV5Y>.
 2. Assist, Game. "'Everything Is Political': Institutional Racism in Life Is Strange 2." YouTube, June 15, 2020. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Af9kcJ59NGI>.
 3. Chen, Esme. "Revisiting the Politics of Life Is Strange 2 Seven Years Later: Redbrick Slider (Gaming)." Redbrick, October 30, 2025. <https://www.redbrick.me/revisiting-the-politics-of-life-is-strange-2-seven-years-later/>.
 4. Clark, Justin. Review: Life Is Strange 2 Boldly and Directly Plumbs America's Darkness, December 16, 2019. <https://www.slantmagazine.com/games/review-life-is-strange-2-boldly-and-directly-plumbs-americas-darkness/>.
 5. Dramatic_Amoeba_2535. "R/Lifeisstrange2 on Reddit: Why Is Life Is Strange 2 so Hated?" Reddit, 2024. https://www.reddit.com/r/LifeisStrange2/comments/Idvvaot/why_is_life_is_strange_2_so_hated/.
 6. "Life Is Strange 2 Reviews." Metacritic, 2018. <https://www.metacritic.com/game/life-is-strange-2/>.
 7. PurpleFiner4935. "I Can't Help but Think That Life Is Strange 2 Aged Very Well." Reddit, 2025. https://www.reddit.com/r/lifeisstrange/comments/lje3oj4/all_i_cant_help_but_think_that_life_is_strange_2.
 8. romanode. "How Life Is Strange 2 Builds the Perfect Finale." YouTube, May 21, 2025. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SjCkE0jjY5E>.
 9. romanode. "The Disappointing Decline of Life Is Strange." YouTube, February 11, 2026. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tv57zqDMY9c>.

Somewhere in Between

Markus Chu

"Each of us lives, dependent and bound by our individual knowledge, and our awareness. All that, is what we call 'reality.' However, both knowledge and awareness are equivocal. One's reality might be another's illusion. We all live inside our own fantasies." — Itachi to Sasuke.

Reality and delusion seem like complete opposites, but the more time you spend with them, the less clear it becomes. They both consist of what we think is true and what we want to be true, and most of the time, those two things are so intertwined that we cannot say which one is which anymore. We want to believe we see things as they truly are, the truth. However, so much of what seems reality has already been distorted by what we have gone through, what we feel, and what we need to make sense of it. So the question is not really whether we distort things. It is if we even notice it.

Reality shifts around what we want from it. Memory clouds the line between the two; our brain fills in the gaps, and eventually, what we are left with the version of it we could live with. Even then, we are still holding onto something we know is not fully the truth. No one says it as saying it means to admit that we believe we put it together ourselves, quietly, without ever letting anyone see the truth.

All I had ever known was war, how to kill, how to follow orders, and a loyalty that only ever went one way: toward the Major. When I came back from a battle that had taken both my arms, I was not grieving my body or thinking about what I had lost. I was waiting. For orders. For him. I was told he would not be back yet, and while I waited, I was put to work as an auto memory doll: someone who

sat with people and turned what they were feeling into letters they could not bring themselves to write. Something changed in me doing that work. I started to understand what grief actually felt like from the inside. I learned what love asks of people. I saw how easily people break and how much they need each other, and somewhere in all of that, I stopped being the girl who had gone to war.

Reality struck. I found out the major had died that night. He was gone this whole time, and no one said a word. Maybe to protect me, maybe because they thought they could have me live the rest of my life, and that I'd eventually forget about him. It does not matter why. The truth came out, and something in me broke. I could not fully accept it, because there was no body found. He had been declared dead, but there was nothing I could actually hold in my hands and say, this is proof. I was left with two choices, but I couldn't decide. I was not quite grieving and not quite hoping, just stuck asking the same questions over and over. Was he really gone? Was I holding onto something real, or just something I wanted to be real? If I kept thinking he might still be alive, was that delusion? And if I accepted he was dead, was that being strong, or was it just giving up on him?

I didn't have the full truth. Maybe that is the point of all this? Sometimes delusion is not about not accepting the truth. Maybe it is what we need to survive, either temporarily or for the rest of our lives. I couldn't accept handling reality. I was holding on because letting go meant losing him twice, once out there in the war, and once inside my own head. And there are some losses that are too close together. You cannot be asked to do both at once.

The Major had his own version of this. What he suffered was not a wound. It was a choice he had made about a girl. He taught me to read and write, and tried to teach me about life outside of the war. However, he also let me stay as a weapon, and that cost me the chance to have a normal life. When I eventually saw him again, I do not think even he knew exactly why he had stayed away for so long. Had he given me room to become someone whole? Or was he running from what he had been part of? Was it staying love, or was it just guilt dressed up as something warmer? That uncertainty is not a flaw; it is simply what happens when someone tries to accept

reality but is not fully able to, no matter how hard they try.

Memory is the source of it all and makes everything blurry. It does not just hold onto what happened; it rewrites it slowly, without asking. It softens the harsh, unbearable truth, and after a while, absence turns into presence if you ignore it. My memory of the Major was not a record. It was something I had built and kept rebuilding out of grief and gratitude and the particular kind of need that does not go away just because the person does. The version of him I carried was not exactly him. It never is, with anyone we lose.

We all know we should believe in the harsh reality, no matter how painful it is. However, maybe we cannot, and that is okay; maybe we end up somewhere in the middle. Our wants always pull us in one direction, and we do not even feel it happening most of the time. Reality is not something handed to us whole. We create it, protect it, and ignore it, because carrying all of it at once is more than most people can do.

—

1. Barrett, Lisa Feldman. "Your Brain Doesn't Detect Reality. It Creates It." YouTube, July 13, 2023. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ikvrwOnay3g>.
2. bazdaddy420. "The Most Painful Depiction Of Love In Anime." YouTube, July 12, 2025. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=a3g_c7Qhjlq.
3. Big Think. "Is Reality Real? These Neuroscientists Don't Think so | Big Think." YouTube, September 12, 2021. https://youtu.be/RZdfE_7cde0?si=A2ed_YzLcMXTJHun.
4. Nyaa, Kevin. "How Violet Evergarden Crafted An Emotional Masterpiece." YouTube, August 29, 2021. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=umb8WwJ5Jlo>.
5. Ishidate, Taichi, dir. Violet Evergarden. Kyoto Animation, 2018. Television series. Netflix, April 5, 2018. <https://www.netflix.com/title/80182123>.
6. Sadhguru. "Reality vs. Imagination." YouTube, May 8, 2015. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=69_7UkdXKVk.
7. Seth, Anil. "Your Brain Hallucinates Your Conscious Reality | Anil Seth | TED." YouTube, July 18, 2017. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lyu7v7nWzfo>.
8. Thew, Geoff. "Learning Empathy - Violet Evergarden's Beautiful Writing." YouTube, March 20, 2018. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=d_fMfH3ew4U.

Persona: Master the Self

Masa

The series Persona is a widely popular series due to its incorporation of aesthetics involving its graphics, ideals, and gameplay. However, the recent games stand out greatly from the rest. Persona 3, 4, and 5 are the most recently developed games that have gained the most attention from the series audience. Each game blatantly reflects the ideals of Swedish Psychologist and Philosopher Carl Jung who is most known for his theories on archetypes and the collective unconscious.

As I scroll through the internet, I notice the series gaining more traction with each year. As with any fanbase, you have the newer players who are most vocal on the internet about the series in an attempt to seek attention. In reaction, there is of course the other side of the spectrum, the people who were likely chastised in the past for their interest in the series, and now attempt to flex their patronage to the series while also complaining about the previously aforementioned newcomers who seem to be riding the bandwagon.

I personally do my best to allow a different side of a media fanbase to invade my free time. The people regardless of time spent on the series decide to analyze gameplay and story mechanics in an attempt to deconstruct the different ways media in general can hold influence to the public.

I've been inspired by the YouTuber Tehsnakerer, a creator who does a sort of synopsis/retrospective on video games in addition to analyzing game mechanics such as combat, side quests, and film techniques in an attempt to finally give an assertion on a game and the overall meaning behind it. However, I have yet to see such an in depth analysis on Persona in its different techniques, just general synopses and some reactionary

elements such as creators actively taking inspiration from the Persona games while being unaware of the Jungian Psychology incorporated into the game mechanics which sparked that idea in the first place.

With all that information, I wonder to myself, how much has the fanbase been influenced by these concepts and how have they been incorporated to match and critique Japanese society? From a gameplay standpoint, it is a turn-based JRPG like Pokemon, with Personas serving as the attackers and defenders in combat.

However, in addition to types, the game also includes arcanas from the tarot deck that translate to the native Personalities of each Persona. For example, the Persona Thor obtainable in the endgame is under the chariot arcana because it embodies the young hero archetype defined by Jung. Although not a blatant explanation as the game never specifies it, the entities from different religions as Personas allows the audience to make connections with each of the visual characters and be able to identify archetypes through these familiar entities.

The arcanas are directly linked to different supporting characters as well. Most characters in the game are additionally offered as social links. Spend enough time with each link and the Link's rank will go up. The maximum level of each rank is 10, and the higher it is, the quicker a Persona of that arcana can increase as well. Similar to my example Persona, a character who embodies the chariot will once again have heroic qualities and may show bravery or courage in dangerous situations.

The juxtaposition of the Personas and Social links may as well be a direct comparison of a person's qualities to a mythical being. I think this once again can allow the player to take each characteristic seriously and ask themselves if they can be brave like Thor or have the intellect of Athena, and so on.

The games also highlight the series theme of hard work. This is demonstrated through the mechanic of social stats, a set of skills the player starts out with at a very mediocre level. These stats can be leveled up to the 5th or 6th level depending on the game doing what the developers think would improve the stat. For

example, if the player wants to improve their knowledge, they can get questions right when called on in class, read a book, watch an educational movie, or study outside of class. This isn't done in a short amount of time, however. For a social stat to increase a level, a player must do these tasks for 15–20 in game days, and progress to the next level is unable to be viewed at all from the player's point of view.

This very clearly reflects the Jungian idea of mastering the self. In my eyes, this mechanic does a great job in getting the idea across. Not only can the player understand benefits of the mundane without having to learn the long way, but the concept may also warrant some introspection. A player might ask themselves how high their charm or courage is in real life, and what they can do to raise that stat, perhaps inspiring people to be more intentional with the time that they have.

As much as the series does to warrant hard work, it does just as much to criticize the ideals of nihilism and lack of conviction through a modern lens. In Persona 3 and 4, the antagonists are nihilistic and do what they can to bring the world down with them, even when fighting directly with people who have strong beliefs and a sense of purpose who directly contradict theirs. In Persona 5, the antagonists are powerful beings created by the wishes of the people who don't know what they are living for or have little purpose in life.

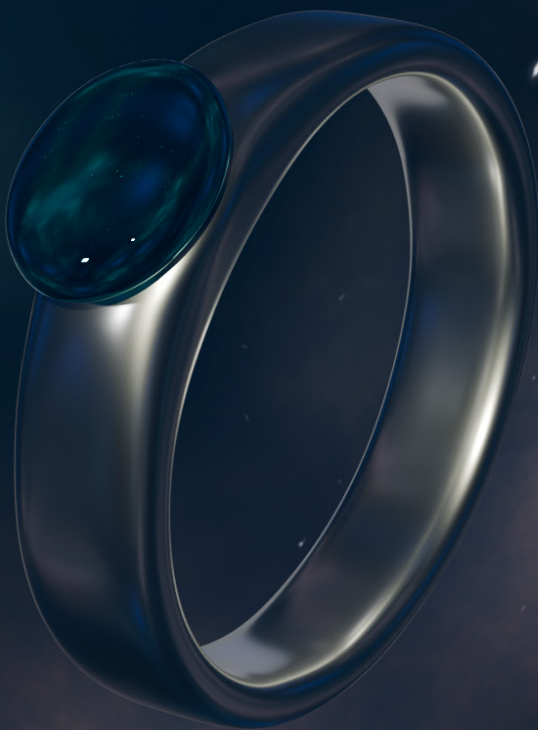
The game even punishes you for this too. In Persona 5, you lead a group of vigilantes who change the hearts of ill intentioned people and you get caught by the police. You get the option to choose to rat out your team later in the game. If you do this, you die. That's it. You get shot in the head and the credits roll. Hope you've been cautious with your save files.

I find this to be interesting. It makes sense. If you do go with any of the nihilistic choices and pull people down with you, how are you any different from the villains? I think the point here is to reinforce that even if you don't have a sense of purpose, it's important to not pull down those who do.

With all this information, I believe that the point of the Persona series is a blatant call to action to the player. Looking through an analytical lens at gameplay mechanics, the games make an attempt to give the sense of productivity to the mundane. There's a tangible currency in different daily actions such as studying or answering questions right during class. You can even acquire skill points doing things such as playing video games or going to an arcade. Things that may seem boring or insignificant to some can take a complete 180 when looked at through a different lens. Watching movies or playing video games can make you more knowledgeable or give you emotional intelligence. Although studying may seem boring, it can improve concentration and allow you to experience more joy in other aspects of life. Having a variety of friends and social connections can give insight into different beliefs and allow for ideals to be challenged. The game truly does everything it can to brighten up every aspect of life. Every action big or small is highlighted. In the eyes of the game, any social connection no matter the demographic is accepted in the eyes of the game if it piques the player's interest. In short, the overall message of the game is to live life with more intention and experience the moment with every action you take because time cannot be bought back.

—

1. Jung, C. G., and R. F. C. Hull. The archetypes and the collective unconscious. London: Routledge, 2014.
2. Moore, Robert L., and Douglas Gillette. King, warrior, magician, lover: Rediscovering the archetypes of the mature masculine. San Francisco: HarperOne, 2013.
3. "Tehsnakerer." YouTube. Accessed April 14, 2026. <https://www.youtube.com/@Tehsnakerer/videos>.





Kitten's Perfect Studio

Melissa Delaney

Koneko no Studio is a Japanese animated short released on April 9, 1959 and produced by Yasuji Mori of Toei Animation. It was issued in the English language as Kitty's Studio or Kitten's Studio. The short follows a tan and white kitten trying to make a film with two gray and white mice as the actors. The kitten gets frustrated because the mice kept messing up their parts or the equipment kept falling apart. So, the kitten makes a new and better studio. The kitten also has a machine that is able to duplicate anything the machine reads, and the kitten creates replicas of the mice to be the actors.

The mice start playing around with the new equipment including the duplication machine. Now, little robots are all over the studio, and the kitten and the mice team up to get rid of all the robots. They reset all of the robots back into the machine. The kitten and mice leave the robot mice and robot kitten to run the studio as they leave. When they closed the doors behind them was when the short ends.

Chaos and flawlessness were a constant battle within the short. The kitten wants the film to go through flawlessly, while the mice intentionally and unintentionally cause chaos within both of the studios. The short ends with no conclusion if disorder or order wins. That part of the story is open-ended with robot kitten and mice taking over the studio. It's chaotic to leave robots to run the studio by themselves, but the robots themselves had the perfectionist mindset of the kitten since the kitten made them. So, mayhem and perfection both win and lose in a way.

Disarray can not exist without order existing as well. Kitty's Studio shows what happens if one of these concepts takes over a

space. When the kitten made the new studio and everything was perfect and in order, the space became very bland. The studio became boring, and everything just went straight to the point with no mishaps interrupting the kitty from making the film. Then, the mice started chaos, and it became the control in the room. The robots were causing chaos everywhere, and the kitty could not focus on making the film when the robots were attacking them. The mice were having fun at first when there was a little chaos, but the mice were getting attacked too by the robots. That is when the mice realized they caused too much chaos, and the mice tried to help the kitten to stop the robots together.

The short shows the extreme opposites of disorganization and organization, and what happens to the space when the extreme perfection or chaos occurs. The short also demonstrates when havoc and impeccability are in balance. This is shown at the beginning and end of the short. It is a little disorderly in the beginning because everything keeps falling apart, and the end is a little organized with perfectionist robots taking over the reins of the studio. This is perfectly symbolized with the Yin and Yang symbol for perfect balance. There is a little harmony in disharmony and a little harmony in disharmony.

Koneko no Studio is a Japanese 1959 film about a kitten trying to make a film with mice. While they are trying to film, the short indicates the extreme chaos and perfection and the balance between them. Too much of flawlessness leads to a dreary environment, and too much madness causes danger and less productivity. This short also shows what the Yin–Yang symbol represents and the balance between two concepts. It is okay to have a little disorder in order, and a little order in the disorder.

Night in the woods: Girl alone in a world

Sara Simensky

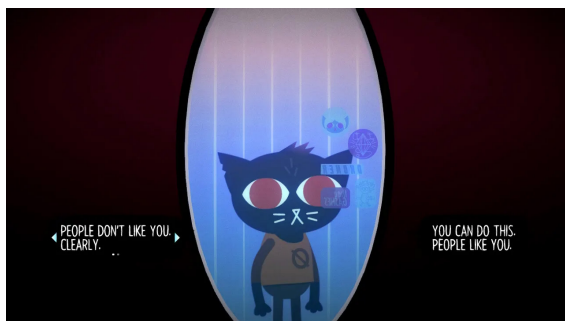
Spoilers ahead...



For preface, I am a 20-year-old mentally ill woman. Many years of my adolescent life were defined by the institution of therapeutics, but I don't let this define me. I would like to think that I have a basic knowledge of not only my own disorders, but also the many others I've been exposed to through my various institutions. Now that that is disclosed, let's move on to another mentally ill 20 year old woman I would like to discuss. I don't play many video games, but I was curious about a steam game called *Night in the Woods* (2017). Our protagonist is a 20-year-old girlfailure who is also a black cat, Mae. At the start of the game, Mae has dropped out of college for reasons she won't divulge and is returning home to possum springs to live with her parents. Things are strange in Possum Springs. Located on the rust belt of America, the town is decaying, stores are closing, people are moving, resources are waning—why would Mae want to return to this? Despite the failing town, Mae's self and life back home seems decently normal when she returns home. She plays bass, she keeps a journal, doodles ACAB in the margins, and she has some friends from high school she's in a band with. Gregg, a very friendly dog who works at the snack store, and Angus, his serious seeming boyfriend (Who might be an otter??? and lastly, a goth lizard named Bea who works at her family's repair shop. There are many other townspeople who sit around outside that Mae can interact with

and learn from, too,— such as a punk kid bear named Selmers, who writes surprisingly good poetry.

Mae hasn't exactly succeeded in life yet, but she seems normal, at first. As you spend more time playing, Mae's actions and the choices you can make for her become more negative, she embarrasses herself in front of a former situationship



at a party. You, as the player, can't choose to avoid it for her. No matter how badly you don't want to see her make a fool of herself. She steals, she convinces her friends to steal, she cries in the mirror, she gets anxious bordering on neuroticism, she gets in fights with her friends and loses her temper, as well as having a seemingly very bad overall reputation in her town. Mae is definitely troubled and that's pretty obvious, but then there's another thing: When Mae goes to sleep every night when you finish the day's gameplay, sometimes she'll have a dream.

The dreams are dim and scary and located in a spooky forest with dilapidated structures. In my opinion, "mini games" are the hardest game play. The game becomes a platformer where there are four posts in the ground each corresponding to a ticket booth somewhere within the forest that hosts a musician and one instrument. When you find these booths they light up, and the musician begins playing his instrument. When you find him, the corresponding post will light up. When you light up all four posts, the song is complete and the dream setting will rumble, revealing a giant realistic depiction of a forest animal, such as a wolf or a crow. Then Mae wakes up and you just... go about your day. It is later revealed that Mae suffers from severe dissociation and derealization as well as major depression and anxiety. It is revealed at some point in late high school that Mae had physically attacked a student due to a mental breakdown. She says that she saw everybody as "meaningless shapes" denoting her experience of severe derealization. As a result of this assault She got the nickname of "Killer" in her town and her parents ran into

financial issues, presumably due to having to pay for the victims medical care. In college things didn't magically get better, as they tend not to do. Mae begins dissociating, withdrawing herself and staying in her room, seeing people as shapes again, and is forced to drop out for her own wellbeing. How does being called "Killer" change how Mae views herself? Even though she left the name-callers behind in possum springs for a period of time, I wonder how the connotations of a name like that changed Mae's perception of herself and her values.

There are thousands of people that can relate to Mae's story, especially other girlfailures trying to find a place in the world. I can't say I relate to Mae's being the "Killer," but I missed half of high school for mental health reasons. So after coming back, I definitely had a bit of a reputation as, well, crazy. I thought all of my problems would go away in college, that I would have a fresh start, that the PTSD and depression would automatically leave my life, and I would be happy and clean and perfect. And well? No, this absolutely didn't happen. I have had some insanely difficult times in college—let alone the culture shock of independent living after having my entire life restricted down to the privilege of going outside. What I am trying to say is that I feel for Mae. I relate to her. During the gameplay, I was her. I haven't dropped out of college but I've come pretty close to just giving up and living in my parent's house. Many other 20 year old women are in that same spot; whether going back to living with their parents, being painfully unemployed, staying in bed all day everyday, truly and utterly giving up on living a "normal" life, or in extreme cases, any life at all.

Night in the woods isn't just a story, for many girls who struggle, it is a painful reality, with no mini games. It is a fact that college aged women (ages 18-25) face the highest prevalence of mental illness of any group. This is a peculiar and huge problem that needs more attention. While the male loneliness epidemic is talked about tenfold, there is limited conversation, or even space, for women to talk about the extremely real mental health problems they are facing without it being chalked up to "feminine sensitivity" or hormones. It is a fact that women—especially young women, who are more likely to be dismissed by doctors when it comes to both mental and physical health.



Studies show that 46% of women aged 18 to 35 in 2024–2026 report negative healthcare experiences where they were either directly dismissed, misdiagnosed, or mistreated. This limits young women’s access to care as well as discourages them from finding care that will actually help them. If there is more awareness drawn to this issue, there can be more readily available resources for young women and girlfailures, and anyone who deserves to be seen and heard despite her issues. If Mae had real and proper support where her voice was respected and not put down, she might have been in a better place and not had to uncover mysteries about her dying town. Of course then there would be no game, but the real Maes all over the world deserve the time.



-
1. Law, James. 2018. "Night in the Woods and Representation of Mental Illness." Medium. March 15, 2018. https://medium.com/@jameslaw_68046/night-in-the-woods-and-representation-of-mental-illness-dbab9ef155c8.
 2. Armstrong, Noelle, Ziyang Fu, and Kathleen Woolf. 2024. "The Relationship between Lifestyle Behaviors and Mental Illness in Women in College." *Nutrients* 16 (14): 2211–11. <https://doi.org/10.3390/nu16142211>.
 3. Fink, Sarah. 2021. "5 Tips to Improve Women’s Mental Health in College." *TimelyCare*. March 29, 2021. <https://timelycare.com/blog/womens-mental-health-in-college/>.
 4. "The Real Horror of Night in the Woods." n.d. *Believer Magazine*. <https://www.thebeliever.net/logger/the-real-horror-of-night-in-the-woods/>.
 5. Northwell Health. 2021. "Gaslighting in Women’s Health: When Doctors Dismiss Symptoms | Northwell Health." *Www.northwell.edu*. Northwell Health. 2021. <https://www.northwell.edu/katz-institute-for-womens-health/articles/gaslighting-in-womens-health>.



A Super Galaxial Journey

Senai

You get a letter telling you there's something waiting for you at a big festival. You run down to it without a care in the world, skipping and jumping along the path as you see more and more people the closer you get. Everyone's already gathered, celebrating in the night sky, and suddenly meteors start falling. Panic sets in across the festival, flying ships close in shooting cannons, crystal magic falls from the sky freezing the attendees running for safety, everything is in chaos. You try to run through the crowds to get to the main castle, to make sure the one who invited you is safe. After barely dodging meteor after meteor, just as you get to the castle, you see a ball of lightning start emanating from one of the flying ships. Suddenly, an alien spaceship, seemingly signaled by the lightning, hovers over you and the castle. It shoots lasers down and cuts out a massive circle, then the ships harpoon the surrounding area with chains. They all begin to lift off, taking you with it, rocketing all the way to space. You stand at the end of the bridge barely connected to the castle as you balance yourself for dear life. While trying to gather your senses, a flying wizard appears in front of you and strikes you with powerful magic, sending you off to another planet. The flying ships and castle once in front of you supernovas into the void of space, as your vision begins to fade.

Eventually, after being out for who knows how long, you are woken up by a round, star shaped creature. It hovers in front of you for a moment as you stand up and regain your senses, and then something unexpected happens; it transforms into a bunny. Before you can process any of this and consider whether you're really awake or still knocked out, it begins to hop away, urging you to follow it. It leads you to two other bunnies who look just like it, except their ears are golden at the ends rather than white. The

one that led you there requests you play a game of hide and seek with it and the rest of its friends, and before waiting for a reply, they hurry off and disappear. In hopes of finding some answers on where you are or what's going, and with no real other options, you wander around the planet looking for their hiding spots. You gradually become more familiar with this small, grassy planet you woke up on, and slowly but surely you find all the bunnies. Each one turns back into a star creature, the yellow eared ones turning into yellow star creatures, and you finally catch the last one. Once you do, it exclaims its excitement in your ability to catch them all, and says you might be able to help their mother. It turns around to look elsewhere, and your gaze follows. A heavenly light begins to shine in the middle of the planet, and a winding staircase with a platform at the top manifests into existence. The star creatures guide you to it, and as you reach the top, you see a figure shrouded in bright glowing aura.

You're now standing in front of her, as she floats just above the ground with her aura continuing to radiate. She tells you she's been watching you from here, a place she calls "the gateway to the starry sky." She explains that she's the guardian of the cosmos and that she can help you on your journey to save your "special one," the one who invited you to the festival. In order to do this you'll need the power to travel through space, so she entrusts you with the care of the star creature you met earlier, who will be your guide and strength. The guardian explains that disaster had come to her and her family among the stars, and she hopes that with your guide you will be able to rescue the stolen cosmic relics. She sends you on your way in a magical star-shaped launch pad, and you begin flying through space. Shortly after, you land on a small pseudo-planet that looks more engineered than natural, and its gravity is in the range of several similar pseudo-planets. The more you look around, you begin to piece together where you've been sent, you're in enemy territory. You see some of the same airships flying around that caused the destruction of the festival to begin with, and you see in the distance a pseudo-planet larger than the rest. Maybe the cosmic relic the guardian mysteriously mentioned earlier was being held there. With new vigor and the help of your guide, you defeat enemy after enemy, and traverse between these engineered geoclusters floating through space. Relatives of the

star creatures you had run into earlier assist you along the way, transforming into the magical launch star that brought you here to take you further and further until finally, you reach the biggest planet. There's an entrance that's locked off by a key, which you conveniently had obtained from a prior enemy encounter. After unlocking the cage around it, you enter a tube that takes you to its core. There, you see it at the center, a glowing star emanating with energy, being drained by some strange machinery.

Blue colored switches are plotted all over the ground, with electrified platforms rotating around the area. You're informed by a star creature inside that you have to hit all the switches to shut it down, while narrowly avoiding being electrocuted. Carefully, you navigate through the hazardous core and manage to shut down the machine. Suddenly, the glowing star bursts out of the center of the machine with a newfound vibrancy. You inch closer, and you feel something pulling you towards it, almost as if it's calling to you. You reach out, and in the blink of an eye, you and the star blast off into deep space. Eventually, you land on a very dimly lit space station, and the star that carried you here begins to spin. It rotates faster and faster until it shoots itself into the heart of the space station, where a small orb of energy lies. The orb absorbs the star, and doubles in size, causing half the station, including the center, to slowly begin lighting up. You walk further into the path in front of you, and you see the same cosmic guardian from earlier. She turns around to you, and thanks you for rescuing the relic. She explains that this place is called the "Comet Observatory," home to her and the star creatures, who are her family. This observatory, she continues, is also a ship that she and her family use to travel the starry skies. They pass by this area once every one hundred years, but were suddenly stopped by a strange force. It drained the cosmic power from the ship, causing it to enter a state of hibernation. The ones who did this, the strange force, are the same ones who caused the chaos at the festival. While the rescued relic did help bring back power to the ship, it isn't nearly enough to travel to the center of the universe, where the dark forces reside. It does, however, have enough power to locate and search for more relics to fully power the ship. In a plea for the well being of your special one, her family, and the universe, the guardian asks if you will help her on this mission, traveling from galaxy to galaxy in order to return power to the

ship, and balance to the stars. You think about everyone who was left at the festival, frozen in fear, the star creatures, who've helped you every step of the way, and lastly, of your "special one." You look into the distance, you're tens, hundreds, maybe even thousands of years away from your home. However scared and alone you may feel though, it is outweighed by your compassion for the people around you, both old and new. You look back at the guardian, and tell her you'll take on this journey, one that will determine the fate of the very cosmos.

Milgram, I'm so confused but, I'm invested

Frank Agama Perez

Hey guys, have you heard about the game where you vote a teen mom guilty for the murder of her own child? Milgram is an ongoing interactive music video project where 10 prisoners who have been incarcerated for the crime of MURDER!, and you have to watch music videos to vote whether their crime is forgivable or unforgivable.

Under the watch of a prison guard who lost their memories, Es functions as a stand for you. As the guard, you have the power to deem the crime of these criminals either forgivable or unforgivable, be careful as you won't know the truth behind their crimes.

The way you learn about each prisoner's crimes is via music videos, uploaded on the "Milgram" YouTube channel. These music videos are an extraction of the prisoners' memories of the murder, while some are clear and show the events leading up to the murder, others can be vague and need to be theorised using context clues. Once a music video is uploaded, you get a period where you have the opportunity to vote whether the crime is forgivable or unforgivable on the Milgram website. Each prisoner will undergo 3 trials, each trial having a new music video, hopefully providing further context, more clues, and a chance to change your vote. The prisoners are made aware of the verdict, the result of the vote influencing future trials, as it can alter their beliefs of their crimes, affecting future music videos.

It is important to note that this game is based in Japan, so all official information, including the website, is in Japanese; however, there have been official subtitles for the music videos and parts of the site. However, one thing that has been "mistranslated" is the voting, being forgivable and unforgivable.

In English, it was translated to “innocent” and “guilty”, so moving forward, I will be using the English terms, innocent and guilty.

But you are not alone.

Milgram is an interactive music video project, hosted on YouTube and the Milgram website, where you get to watch and cast votes, so can other people! COLLECTIVELY! Voting lasts several months between video releases; each vote is tallied up, and the final verdict is based on the majority. With theories developing over time with more clues, new perspectives being formed, and old theories resurfacing, debates of a trial can vary from a clear cut “she 100%” innocent to a “what the fuck guilty guilty guilty!!!”

What specifically interests me is how various people’s reactions and their verdicts are, and how different communities view a prisoner’s crime. Especially when Milgram covers heavy topics like suicide, abortion, and death. All of which falls into a moral grey since the focus is on the actions and motivations of a prisoner’s crime rather than their backstory.

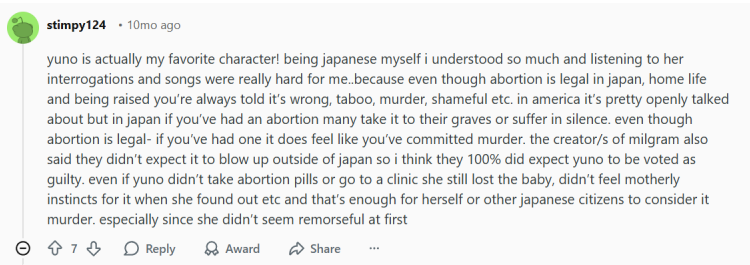
Prisoner No. 2: Yuno, Innocent, 90.55%

Prisoner number 2, Yuno. We are introduced to Yuno in the song “Umbilical,” with future songs being “Life” and “Tear Drop.” Yuno is a female high school student who works as a sugar baby/compensated dating. Offering her body and time for money and affection, she goes on dates with multiple men, with these dates leading to prostitution. Unfortunately, this led to an unexpected pregnancy. With a realization that she doesn’t know who the father is, this causes stress to build up, causing her to have



suicidal thoughts, and either intentional or not, however, most believe it to be accidental– she falls off the stairs, resulting in the death of her child.

What is peculiar about Yuno's murder is that, Milgram, a Japanese-centered project, Yuno's trial revolves around the stigma that Japanese women face regarding sex and childbirth. Prostitution/sex work is illegal, although compensated dating/sugar babying isn't illegal, and in fact, has a large industry backing it; these dates would lead to sex. The larger issue regards abortion; although legalized for several years, abortion has not been widely adopted by the public. As it is considered murder, access to abortion services and products is limited and difficult to come by normally, and to those who are in a similar situation



as Yuno were, they don't know who the father is, it is a lot more difficult, if not impossible.

However, this 90.55% innocent verdict was unprecedented. Being a heavy topic for Japanese audiences, it was believed that there would be lots of debate, but the sudden explosion in popularity among Western audiences caused a heavy imbalance, as abortion is a lot more accepted.

Prisoner No. 4: Muu, Innocent, 50.34%

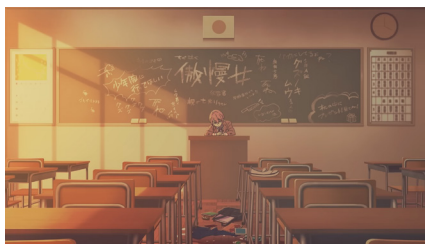
Prisoner number 4 Muu. Muu was introduced in the song "After Pain," then "It's Not My Fault" and "Pain." Muu is a female high school student who is being tormented and bullied at school by a group of girls. As we watch the first video, we see her in front of a chalkboard with death threats pushed down to the floor with her stuff all over the floor, and water splashed on her by this group of girls. Enduring so much of this bullying, she blames



herself for saying “I guess some of it is my fault... Is it ok if I breathe?” As others react to the video, they start siding with her because she is being bullied, even saying that even if she kills all her bullies, she is innocent in their eyes. As the video progresses, we watch Muu run up to one of the girls, grabbing her arm and pleading something inaudible. The girl pulls away, and Muu crashes out, stabbing her.

With the question raised, is killing your bully justifiable? Many would agree, but in what context?! What makes this difficult is that the victim, whose name we later learn is Rei, was present when Muu was getting bullied, when she was murdered, and she was walking home doing nothing to Muu. To which people started backing out of their original, innocent verdict. As

it was not really in self-defence. Trying to prove her innocence, people questioned if she was of sane mind since it was told to us the mention of a suicide note, the line “I don’t want to come tomorrow”, and being miserable at school, leading people to speculate that she’s depressed, and the reason that she ran to Rei wanting to kill herself in front of her but something going wrong leading to her death. Another theory gained popularity stemming from the suicide note, as it said “I love YOU,” it was thought that Muu had some sort of crush or romantic relationship with Rei, who outed her. This brings up the question of lesbian relationships and the harassment that LGBT+ people encounter, justifying



murder? Or Muu killed her because she just stood there doing nothing.



@plokijum 2 years ago
She's def guilty but i forgave her for the bangers she's given us

👍 9 🗨 Reply

And well others...



@coralness 11 months ago
one important thing i'd like to highlight: prisoners CANT LIE in the songs/mv's, it's directly extracted from their subconscious. there is no "manipulation" or "lies" within the songs, they give you insight on the actual mindset of the characters, show you how the characters think, they can also show things that characters themselves don't realise, but the characters don't choose what's shown and can't manipulate the footage in any way. waiting for more milgram!

👍 82 🗨 Reply

This is confusing. We know so much, yet so little. We feel bad for her and want to vote her innocent, but because of how vague the entire situation is, the final decision came to 50.34% innocent.

Prisoner No. 4: Muu, Guilty, 74.46%

What the fuck!???

-
1. DECO*27, "MILGRAM," 坂井智成(arma bianca), accessed 4/17/2026, <https://milgram.jp/>
 2. Fandom, "Kashiki Yuno," accessed April 22, 2026, https://milgram.fandom.com/wiki/Kashiki_Yuno
 3. Fandom, "Kusunoki Muu," accessed April 22, 2026, https://milgram.fandom.com/wiki/Kusunoki_Muu
 4. GIRL MEAT, "Gaslight Gatekeep Girlboss | Milgram" Sep 5, 2022, MP4, 3:49, Gaslight Gatekeep Girlboss | Milgram
 5. InkWrites, "Is her crime really just...? | MILGRAM Yuno Trial 1 | Fantasy Author Reacts" May 12, 2025, MP4, 43:35, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lki_Sj_mcgU
 6. InvisiClown, "MILGRAM: Japan's Greatest Social Experiment," Aug 12, 2025, MP4, 22:14, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nIH_pTLcQ2Y
 7. JonnTsay, "Bullied Girl Tricked us all... (Milgram React | Second Trial)" Dec 15, 2024, MP4, 1:40:44, Bullied Girl Tricked us all... (Milgram React | Second Trial)



CONTRIBUTORS



Ana Pierowski

I am currently a sophomore at VCU studying kinetic imaging and creative writing. Apart from making art, my pastimes include reading, gaming, and exploring Richmond!



Camerin McManus

VCU Kinetic Imaging student with a main focus in sound, sound design, and music. He loves hiking, rock climbing, skateboarding, urban exploring, snowboarding, listening to music, and playing with synthesizers.

G.A.AA

[is] Someone who doesn't know where their journey will lead them. It's easy being reserved, but I decided to be open and share a piece of me here. I hope that it gives you something.



Gabe

I'm an artist that specializes in narrative storytelling through animated media and horror. I love to explore the comfort that can come from an unexpected place and showcase the beauty of finding relief in the dark.



Grayson Carter

Grayson is an art student from Maryland who spends most of his time sitting in the dark little corner of his room, drawing tiny pictures for the mice and bugs that pay his rent.



Jake Mullins

Hello! I am Jake Mullins and I am a big fan of Japanese media from the 1960s and 1970s! I also love Nintendo games and anime. My favorite series is a 60s puppet show called Hyokkori Hyotanajima!

Julia Velazquez

A second year VCU student with a major in Kinetic Imaging. Special interests include illustration, digital painting, and video games. Level 3290 on Royal Match.



Katy Kunberger

I am a vintage-style cartoon animator but likes to play video games and watch anime as well. I am the creator of nostalgic and vintage inspired cartoons such as The Merry Makers and The Crows Nest. I also love cats! In animation and in reality!



Luka Tenney

Luka is a 3rd year Kinetic Imaging Major who enjoys coding, 3D modeling, and playing video games (though he is bad at them). He's is a prospective video game maker and hopes to work for an indie gaming company. He is a father to two cats named Cheese and Apple <3.



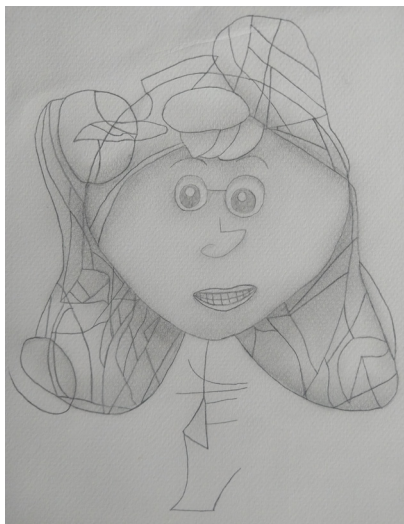
Markus Chu

Markus Chu is an ambitious virtual reality designer and 3D modeler, skilled in utilizing various software applications, including Blender, Cinema 4D, Maya, and Unreal Engine. He possesses proficiency in programming languages such as Java, C, and HTML, as well as expertise in Adobe applications including Premiere Pro, Photoshop, and Audition. Currently, he is enrolled in the Bachelor of Fine Arts program, majoring in Kinetic Imaging at Virginia Commonwealth University.



Masa

I am a 3D/Motion generalist. In my free time, I like to spend it asking questions, whether that be about nature, psychology, media, and storytelling. My hobbies include fishing, bowling, video games, walking reading, and admittedly anything that doesn't include baggage. Recently, I've been interested in anatomy, body and object mechanics, and having a better understanding in storytelling through symbolism and form rather than words.



Melissa Delaney

I'm an animation major, and have a deep love for any animated content! My introduction to video games was with the PS3 with my family, and it's a very nostalgic console for me! Sorry, Xbox gamers! My boyfriend recently got me into anime, and it's our favorite time to spend together! Gaming and anime can allow people to bond and connect with each other, and I'll always cherish the memories with my family gaming and my boyfriend watching and introducing more anime with me!



Sara Simensky

A 3rd year kinetic imaging major at VCU. Enjoys drawing, signs from the divine, and drinking smoothies. Has a black cat named Magic. Casts spells sometimes. At the moment, has blue hair.

Senai

I like earthbound inspired rpgs, outer space, and cartoons (like avatar the last airbender).



Frank Agama Perez

3rd year KI student, animator, and sound artist interested in mixing sound and music with animation to create viscerally expressive scenes with continuous motion and color.

Facilitation : SHAWNE MICHAELAIN HOLLOWAY

Professor, performance artist, vintage anime fan. NintendoDSi girl. Loves World of Warcraft and Overwatch.







RESOURCE ARCHIVE

An asterisk () has been added when it felt like content warnings would be generally helpful. Becuase many games deal with Reality and some parts of Reality can be harsh and rough, themes in some of the resources below can get sad or sexual or gorey or scary and other potentially uncomfortable things here sometimes. If you have reservations but still are curious, maybe ask a friend (who consents) to check the link out before you do. Sometimes a summary from someone you know can either edit language or hold whatever feelings that might come up is also useful.*

Books

1. Roger Calliois, Man, Play and Games – Ch #1 and #2
2. Sheila C. Murphy, Controllers
3. from The Routledge Companion to Video Game Studies
4. A. Scott Glancy, The “I” in Team: War and Combat in Tabletop Role-Playing Games
5. from Zones of Control: Perspectives on Wargaming*
6. Miguel Sicart, We the Soldiers: Player Complicity and Ethical Gameplay in Call of Duty: Modern Warfare,
7. from Zones of Control: Perspectives on Wargaming*
8. Matthew Wysocki, Ctrl-alt-play : essays on control in video gaming
9. **Emilie Reed, Ch. 5, From Tool to Community to Style : The Influence of Software Tools on Game Development and Aesthetics from Indie games in the Digital Age
10. Jesper Juul, The Game, the Player, the World: Looking for a Heart of Gameness
11. Jesper Juul, Zero-Player Games

12. Alexander Galloway, *Counter Gaming from Gaming : Essays on Algorithmic Culture*
13. Sarah Stang, "This Action Will Have Consequences": Interactivity and Player Agency
14. Bo Ruberg, *The Queer Games Avant-Garde : How LGBTQ Game Makers Are Reimagining the Medium of Video Games*
15. Ian Bogost, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Game Studio* from *How to Talk About Videogames*
16. Murray, Salter, and Reed, "Futures of Adventure: Kentucky Route Zero and Machines for Getting Lost on Purpose" from *Adventure Games: Playing the Outsider*

Games

1. Dead by Daylight, <https://deadbydaylight.com/>*
2. Diablo, <https://diablo4.blizzard.com/en-us/>
3. Endless Forrest, <https://tale-of-tales.com/TheEndlessForest/index.html>
4. Everhood, <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1229380/Everhood/>
5. Heavy Rain, <https://store.steampowered.com/agecheck/app/960910/>
6. Kentucky Route Zero, <https://kentuckyroutezero.com/>
7. The Path, <https://tale-of-tales.com/ThePath/index.html>
8. Stardew Valley, <https://www.stardewvalley.net/>
9. Superhot, <https://superhotgame.com/>
10. *Queers in Love at the End of the World*, <https://w.itch.io/end-of-the-world>
11. *Untitled Goose Game*, <https://goose.game/>
12. QWOP, <https://www.foddy.net/Athletics.html>
13. Runescape, <https://play.runescape.com/>
14. Undertale, <https://undertale.com/>
15. Unpacking, <https://www.unpackinggame.com/>
16. Octodad, <https://octodad.com/>
17. *Journey*, *Abzû*, *fIOW*, *Flower*, *Sky: Children of the Light*
18. (ThatGameCompany), <https://thatgamecompany.com> + <https://giantsquidstudios.com/>
19. Animal Well, <https://www.animalwell.net/>
20. *Dobutsu No Mori*, <https://animalcrossing.fandom.com/wiki/>

D%C5%8Dbutsu_no_Mori_(game)

21. Disco Elysium, <https://zaumstudio.com/#disco-elysium>
22. Outer Wilds, https://store.steampowered.com/app/753640/Outer_Wilds/
23. Loco Roco, https://store.playstation.com/en-us/product/UP9000-CUSA06090_00-UCUS986620000001
24. Nidhogg, <https://store.steampowered.com/app/94400/Nidhogg/>
25. The Unfinished Swan, <https://www.giantsparrow.com/games/swan/>
26. Bound, https://store.playstation.com/en-us/product/UP9000-CUSA04193_00-BOUNDGAMEUS00001
27. Tearaway [Unfolded], <https://www.playstation.com/en-us/games/tearaway-unfolded/>
28. Little Big Planet Series, <https://www.playstation.com/en-us/games/littlebigplanet-3/>
29. -<https://www.mediamolecule.com/>
30. Vib-Ribbon, <https://www.moma.org/collection/works/162460> (no official link :P)
31. The Longing, https://store.steampowered.com/app/893850/THE_LONGING/
32. World of Goo (1 + 2), https://store.steampowered.com/app/22000/World_of_Goo/
33. Little Inferno, https://store.steampowered.com/app/221260/Little_Inferno/
34. Half-Life Series, <https://www.half-life.com/en/home/>
35. Any Hideo Kojima game (Metal Gear, Death Stranding..), <https://www.kojimaproductions.jp/en>
36. Tomodachi Life, <https://www.nintendo.com/au/games/nintendo-3ds/tomodachi-life/>
37. Katamari Damacy, https://store.steampowered.com/app/848350/Katamari_Damacy_REROLL/
38. Ultrakill, <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1229490/ULTRAKILL/>
39. Rhythm Heaven Fever, https://nintendo.fandom.com/wiki/Rhythm_Heaven_Fever
40. Celeste, <https://www.celestegame.com/>
41. Wind Waker, https://www.zeldadungeon.net/wiki/The_Legend_of_Zelda:_The_Wind_Waker

42. Ico, Shadow of the Colossus, https://www.gendesign.co.jp/E_index.html
43. Castle Crashers, Battleblock Theater, <https://www.thebehemoth.com/>
44. Secret Little Haven, https://store.steampowered.com/app/827290/Secret_Little_Haven/
45. Sticky Business, https://store.steampowered.com/app/2303350/Sticky_Business/
46. Subnautica, <https://subnautica.com>
47. Hollow Knight, <https://www.hollowknight.com/>
48. Valorant, <https://playvalorant.com/en-us/>
49. Warhammer, <https://www.warhammer.com/>
50. Keyforge, <https://keyforging.com/>
51. Crash Bandicoot™ N. Sane Trilogy, https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/crash-bandicoot-n-sane-trilogy-switch/?srsltid=AfmBOoqf8T_EeyXrrK38h-wcXJa_ab09iu04rPoqyEGgPSQ0fYCwsJFG
52. Coming Out Simulator, <https://ncase.me/cos/>
53. Dead Cells, https://store.steampowered.com/app/588650/Dead_Cells/

General Links

- Steam, <https://store.steampowered.com/>
- Game Studies Journal, <https://gamestudies.org/2404>
- The Strong Museum : National Museum of Play, <https://www.museumofplay.org>
- VGA Gallery, <https://vgagallery.org/>
- VGA Zine, <https://vgagallery.org/vga-zine-home>
- ART GAME STUDIES, <http://artgamestudies.org/>
- Journal of Games Criticism, <https://gamescriticism.org/>
- Radical Software Group, <https://r-s-g.org/>

DISPATCHES FROM THE GAMING CLOSET #2 :

I PAUSED MY GAME 2 B W/ U...



PWR'D BY THE P.A.T.C.H. CLINIC, 2026